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RESCUED: Emaciated and lice-infested when found, Lancelot was restored to health at the Carolina Raptor Center; the bald eagle can fly, but he has cataracts and is going blind

By SUSAN LADD
Staff Writer

CHARLOTTE — They're called Queen Charlotte and Prince Raleigh, but the magnificent bald eagles seem above paltry human titles.

Sitting one above the other on tiered perches, they survey the world through piercing yellow eyes. White-feathered heads pivot quickly at the slightest sound and sharply curving beaks emit shrill

MAJESTY IN EXILE

Because of her early contact with humans, she thinks she is a human. Not recognizing owls as her species, she won't breed.

A heart-shaped mask of white feathers frames the owl's face, and her honey-brown feathers look as soft as velvet. But something's not quite right. Her legs bend inward, and her wings are distended down and outward.

"She has rickets," Marcum explains. "She can't fly. Owls are

"They are very dangerous," Pat Marcum, 48, says quietly. "They will go at your face with their beaks."

But these breathtaking creatures will never fly again. Each is missing a wing from encounters with man. Though bald and golden eagles are protected by federal law, at least one a year arrives at the Carolina Raptor Center with gunshot wounds.

Here, on a wooded 57-acre site in Latta Plantation Park, a small staff cares for sick, injured and orphaned raptors. Raptors are birds of prey, including eagles, hawks, falcons, owls, ospreys and vultures. More than 95 percent are injured through human contact — shot, hit by cars, poisoned, electrocuted, trapped or caught in barbed-wire fences.

About 45 percent will recover enough to be released back into the wild. The rest find a permanent home at the center, where they serve as educational tools and living reminders of some men's ignorance and cruelty when dealing with nature.

"This is Zinnia," Marcum says, gently coaxing a barn owl onto her gloved arm. "She's an example of all things that people can do wrong when they take a baby bird off of a nest."

Zinnia is imprinted on humans.

At Raptor Center, birds of prey receive healing and sometimes a second chance at freedom



VICTIM OF GOOD INTENTIONS: Zinnia, a barn owl whose early contact with humans has made her unfit for life in the wild, perches on the hand of Pat Marcum, executive director of the Carolina Raptor Center

meat-eaters, but they were feeding her mashed potatoes."

Zinnia is testament to the need for education about raptors. Though rehabilitation is the most compelling part of the Raptor Center's work, education is its primary mission.

"We feel we can save more birds through education than we can on an individual basis," says Marcum, executive director of the center since 1986.

As the Raptor Center celebrates its 10-year anniversary, construction is under way on an administration building to house offices, classrooms, exhibit areas and a new gift shop. In 10 years, it has treated more than 2,700 birds and presented 5,000 hours of educational programs to more than half a million people.

Like the birds it ministers to, the center's biggest accomplishment is survival. With the exception of a three-year grant from Mecklenburg County, it has operated for the last decade solely on donations.

It was 1979 when biology student Deborah Sue Griffin became interested in caring for birds of prey at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte. The project became a program, and the Carolina Raptor Center was incorpo-

■ More about RAPTOR, F10



UNDER OBSERVATION: Barn owls nap during the day in a flight cage, where they will be exercised and observed to determine whether they are able to return to the wild

Nesting with the enemy: Raptor Center tries not to befriend birds

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rated in 1981 as a private, nonprofit institution. The center soon outgrew the campus and moved to Latta Plantation Park in 1984.

Today, the administrative offices and the hospital are housed in trailers. Between 60 and 70 resident birds are displayed in roomy cages along a winding forest trail. During visiting hours, a few are tethered to perches in an open area, where they can be observed more closely. The hospital and rehabilitation areas are off-limits to the general public.

"These birds are wild, and their best chance for survival is if they remain wild," Marcum says. "The worst thing that can happen is for them to see humans as friendly. Contact with humans is the reason most of them are here."

Birds come from as far away as Philadelphia and Florida, but the majority are from the Carolinas. A network of volunteers across the Southeast is on call to transport injured birds. A major airline, which wishes to remain anonymous, flies them to the center free of charge.

When a bird arrives, it's thoroughly examined to determine the type and extent of injuries. Most testing and treatment is done at the center, and several local veterinarians donate surgical services.

"We try to work quickly so we don't stress them any more than we have to," says Mathias Englemann, 27, rehabilitation coordinator at the center. A full-time volunteer, he learned most of his skills on the job and received additional training at the University of Minnesota's raptor center.

Poisoning is among the most difficult injuries to treat, because there's no way to know the type of poison ingested, Englemann says. But barbed wire produces the worst single injury.

"They tend to tear their tendons," Englemann says. "We've never been able to release one that's been tangled up in barbed wire."

The injured birds must be handled gently but firmly. Most can inflict serious wounds with beaks and talons, so Englemann and his assistants wear heavy gloves. The room is kept as quiet and dark as possible, and leather hoods are placed over the birds' heads to calm them.

"It's a challenge to learn to handle them the right way," Englemann says, because every species is different and each bird has a different personality. Birds most suscep-



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ARMED FOR THE WILD: Mathias Englemann, rehab coordinator for the Raptor Center, sharpens the beak of a barred owl about to be released into the wild after rehabilitation

tible to stress tend to be the smaller species such as Cooper's hawks, peregrine falcons and brown-winged hawks. The most laid-back are red-tailed hawks and screech owls.

"The golden eagles are my favorite," Englemann says, "but all of them are beautiful in their own way — even vultures."

Preparing for freedom

Today, he's examining a barred owl. Found trapped in a chimney, the bird had exposed the tendons on its wing tips in its effort to escape.

Volunteer assistant Monica Bowman-Davis carefully reaches into the ventilated blue box with a gloved hand and grasps the owl's legs. As she lifts it out of the box, it spreads its striped wings in an effort to fly and snaps its beak together as a warning. Bowman-Davis folds the bird's wings against its body and lays it on a table on its back.

Englemann spreads out the right wing and checks each feather individually. Using a small syringe, he takes a blood sample. He takes measurements of the wings, the depth of the beak and the middle tail feather. Then, using a drill, he trims the ragged edges of the owl's beak,

sharpening each contour.

The birds are also banded before release for tracing. The center gets a 1 to 2 percent return on tags. They've found that red-tailed hawks travel 16 to 20 miles after being released, while owls pretty much stay put. Eagles range for hundreds of miles.

As they recover, birds are moved from the hospital trailer to the rehabilitation barn. Sunlight filtering through the wood slats falls on the rich brown feathers of a golden eagle. Two years ago, Betsy and her mate produced a golden eagle chick, the first successful hatching in the center's breeding program. Today it soars over the Georgia mountains.

Another cage contains baby owls, and another kestrels — small falcons. Orphaned birds are often housed with adult birds of the same species to ensure they don't imprint on humans. When they've improved sufficiently, birds move from the barn to 40-foot flight cages, where they're exercised and observed to determine if they're able to return to the wild. Some that remain at the center will be manned, or taught to perch on a glove.

Campbell, a black vulture, learned a little too well. He can fly

away with his perch and take the jesses (leather straps attached to a tether) off his feet. Awaiting training is Lancelot, a bald eagle found emaciated and covered with lice at Kill Devil Hills last fall. Now fit and beautiful, he stalks around his cage like an old general.

"He can fly, but he's going blind," Marcum says. "He has cataracts."

In the public display area, there are hawks, owls, falcons, vultures and, of course, the pair of American bald eagles. One breathtaking resident is an albino red-tailed hawk named Honeysuckle. Lacking protective coloration, the snow-white bird would die in the wild.

Marcum pauses at the screech owl cage, trilling softly to coax a reply from its sleepy residents. Despite the name, the call of this owl is quite melodic.

"Sometimes at night they all cut loose," Marcum says. "You should hear it!"

A screech owl aviary will be part of the new administration building when it's completed at the first of the year. There will also be an outdoor amphitheater where staff members will conduct demonstrations with birds flying freely overhead.

Donated money and time

The construction of the administration building is possible largely through in-kind donations. Contractor Fred Moretti is donating \$100,000 in materials and labor, while other companies are donating grading, paving and other services. The Kathleen Price and Joseph M. Bryan Family Foundation of Greensboro donated \$10,000 to the building.

The center also is funded by memberships, currently numbering 1,000; the Eagle's Landing Gift Shop, and an adopt-a-bird-of-prey program. People who "adopt" a species for a year receive a color portrait of the bird, its history and an adoption certificate. The adoption fees range from \$25 for the small species like kestrels to \$300 for eagles.

There is no admission fee, but donations are encouraged. Some 15,000 people visit the center yearly.

With a staff of only four people and a budget of \$150,000, the center relies on volunteers for assistance in education, rehabilitation, office work and maintenance. A regular group gathers once a week to sort the rats that will be raptor food.

"People are drawn to raptors because they're so majestic," Marcum says. "When I see them flying, I just want to be up there with them."

Raptors are also important environmental indicators, Marcum says. "They're at the top of the food chain, just like us. If they're in trouble, we're going to be in trouble, too."

All raptors are protected under the Migratory Bird Treaty Act, which makes it unlawful to pursue, hunt, capture, kill, possess or sell any migratory bird, or any part of the bird, its nest or eggs. Bald eagles and peregrine falcons are protected as endangered species.

Even so, some 500 injured birds arrive at the center annually. Deborah Sue Griffin, who returned to the Raptor Center four years ago as education coordinator, says it sometimes can be disheartening.

"When I get depressed, I know it's time to go and watch birds that can fly, out in the wild," Griffin says. "These birds represent something we're losing — a power and freedom. When people see them, they see something they wish they could have. If you come under the spell of these birds, it will stay with you forever."

Want to go?

The Carolina Raptor Center is at Latta Plantation Park, 20 minutes north of Charlotte on Sample Road. Take I-85 south to I-77 north and take exit 16-B (Sunset Road west). Turn right on Beatties Ford Road and go 5 miles. Turn left on Sample Road.

Visiting hours are noon to 5 p.m. Wednesday through Sunday, April 1 through Nov. 30. Hours are noon to 5 p.m. on Saturdays and Sundays Dec. 1 through March 31, weather permitting. For more information, call (704) 875-6521.